

NEED FOR A SCIENCE OF HUMAN STRENGTHS AND VIRTUES

While the formal discipline of positive psychology has only existed since 2000,[1] the concepts that form the basis of it have been the subject of empirical study since at least the 1980s,[29][30] and present in religious and philosophical discourse for thousands of years. It has been influenced by humanistic as well as psychodynamic approaches to treatment. Predating the use of the term —positive psychology||, researchers within the field of psychology had been focusing on topics that would now be included under this new denomination

The term positive psychology dates back at least to 1954, when Maslow's first edition of *Motivation and Personality* was published with a final chapter titled "Toward a Positive Psychology." In the second edition published in 1970, he removed that chapter, saying in the preface that "a positive psychology is at least available today though not very widely."

There have been indications that psychologists since the 1950s have been increasingly focused on the promotion of mental health rather than merely treating mental illness. From the beginning of psychology, the field has addressed the human experience using the —Disease Model,|| specifically studying and identifying the dysfunction of an individual.

Positive psychology grew as an important field of study within psychology in 1998 when Martin Seligman chose it as the theme for his term as president of the American Psychological Association. In the first sentence of his book *Authentic Happiness*, Seligman claimed: —for the last half century psychology has been consumed with a single topic only – mental illness,|| expanding on Maslow's comments. He urged(to do something) psychologists to continue the earlier missions of psychology of nurturing talent and improving normal life.

Several humanistic psychologists, most notably Abraham Maslow, Carl Rogers, and Erich Fromm, developed theories and practices pertaining to human happiness and flourishing. More recently, positive psychologists have found empirical support for the humanistic theories of flourishing. In addition, positive psychology has moved ahead in a variety of new directions. In 1984, Diener published his tripartite model of subjective well-being, positing "three distinct but often related components of wellbeing: frequent positive affect, infrequent negative affect, and cognitive evaluations such as life satisfaction."

In this model, cognitive, affective and contextual factors contribute to subjective well-being. According to Diener and Suh, subjective well-being is based on the idea that how each person thinks and feels about his or her life is important."